during the India–Pakistan war. The Soviet Union extended considerable economic assistance and technological support to the building of newly independent India's industrial base and military strength.

The geopolitical backdrop was the escalating Sino–Soviet discord and Pakistan's accession to the US-led military alliances of CENTO and SEATO. The US–China rapprochement in the early 1970s coincided with the India–USSR Treaty of Friendship and Cooperation of 1971, which imparted fresh impetus to Soviet arms supplies to India. Soviet support for the Non-Aligned Movement campaigns for de-colonisation and against apartheid was an important element of India–USSR convergence.

The end of the Cold War and the breakup of the Soviet Union altered the fundamental premises of the India–USSR/India–Russia relationship. As Russia grappled with multiple political and economic challenges, its external focus was on the United States and Europe – as sources of technology and capital, political inspiration, and security guarantees. Political relations and cultural interactions with India were somewhat diluted. Military supplies to India were severely affected by the dismantling of the Soviet military-industrial complex. In India, the collapse of the economic arrangements with the Soviet Union exacerbated a financial crisis. The launch of an ambitious economic reform programme was accompanied by a strong push to strengthen relations with the West, which were now freed from the constraints of the Cold War. A balance was restored in the late 1990s, as increasing differences between Russia and the West on issues of independence and sovereignty led to a recalibration of Russian foreign policy. The Russian strategist Yevgeny Primakov sought to steer Russia away from total dependence on the West and towards a "strategic triangle" of Russia, India, and China (RIC) to balance the global influence of the United States. The concept accorded with India's support for multipolarity in global political and